Research proposals

After identification of the research problem, the next step is the development of research proposal. It's a statement in writing that spells out the researcher's intentions of carrying out a research in a specific area. The proposal outlines the approach, strategy as well as the techniques to be followed in conducting a study. It's a written summary of what a researcher intends to do. A proposal is also known as a work plan, prospectors, and outline. It is a statement of intent or draft plan that tells us what, why, how, where and to whom it will be done. For the student or researcher, it provides a plan of action for approval by supervisor or funding agency.

Purpose of a research proposal

The research proposal is of great importance both to the researcher and the readers for the following reasons

1. It makes known, the intentions of getting involved in research work. This is one through the researcher stating the objectives of the study.
2. The process of writing a proposal allows the researcher to plan and review the steps that would be undertaken in the project. It gives the researcher an opportunity to sport mistakes (flaws) in the logic, errors in assumptions, for problems that are not adequately addressed by the objectives and design of the study.
3. In general, it provides justification for funding. One has to justify the use of resources in the business and consultancy world. In the academic setting, the proposal must justify contribution to either existing knowledge or adding to it.
4. After the proposal is approved, the document serves as a guide for the researcher throughout the investigations.
5. A well designed research proposal helps the researcher to avoid the tiring and time consuming, alterations once the research project takes off.
6. The proposal forces, time management and budget estimates.
7. The proposal is also able to suggest the data necessary for solving the problem and how the data will be gathered and interpreted.
8. A proposal also provides an opportunity for the researcher to discuss the research efforts of others who have worked on related areas.

Note: All research has a sponsor in one form or another. The student researcher is responsible to the class instructor. In a corporate setting, whether the research is being done in house by a research department or under contract to an external research firm, the management sponsors the research. University/government or corporate sponsored research uses grand committees to evaluate the work. A research proposal allows the sponsor to access the sincerity of your purpose, the clarity of your design, the extent of your background material and your fitness for undertaking the project. It also displays your discipline, organization and logic.

Types of research proposals

1. Academic research proposal

2. Project research proposal

In general, project research proposal can be divided into two:-

a. Internal proposal done by the members of staff, specialists of the research department of the organization.

b. External proposal which are either solicited or unsolicited where the sponsors can be universities, government agencies etc. academic research proposals are proposals in which the researcher proposes to undertake a piece of research on some issues leading to a definite academic qualification like diploma, degree (Bachelors, masters, PhD)

STRUCTURE AND FORMAT OF RESEARCH PROPOSAL

Structure of research proposal

The proposal can be structured into three main sections: -

Section One: Preliminary Information

The first one is the title page and should have the following information: -

(a) A clear title.

(b) Name of the student – registration number, department and faculty.

(c) Required fulfillment.

(d) Date. Eg April 2007

Other preliminary information that follows are: -

i) Table of contents

ii) Authority from supervisors

iii) Declaration page

iv) List of figures

v) Acknowledgement/Dedication

Section 2: Body

Chapter 1: Introduction

Background of the problem should be discussed. A well written background gives the statement of the problem.

Purpose of study, objectives of the study, hypothesis, justification of the study, Assumptions of the study, conceptual framework, definition of terms.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

A brief introduction could be given. Theory and theoretical framweork, empirical literature review, summary of literature.

Chapter 3: Research design and methodology

Introduction, research paradigm/philosophy, Research approach, Research design, target population, sampling procedures, sample size and frame, data collection methods, procedures of data collection, data analysis and ethical issues in research.

Section 3: References/Bibliography

Names of authors of the books reviewed, Name of book and the year. For example, Robert W. A (2017). Research Methods, Karatina University Press (2017), Karatina Kenya.

Appendices - time plan, budget,

Sample questionnaires or any other data collection instruments.

Format of research proposal

i) We need to have executive summary/abstract. This allows the reader to understand quickly the main aim of the proposal. It is essentially an informative part that gives the reader the chance to understand the essentials of the proposal without having to read the details.

As such, the abstract should include: -

- Brief statements of the problem and research questions.
- The research objectives
- Benefits of the methodology used
- Some preliminary information on the expected findings.

NB: Ideally an abstract should not exceed one page.

(ii) Introduction/Background of the study

This is meant to stimulate interest of the reader. It acquaints the reader with the problem, provides some background and necessary information about the study. A good introduction should be brief and flow smoothly. A well written introduction should read to the statement of the problem. In an introduction, the researcher should:

- create reader interest in the topic,
- lay the broad foundation for the problem that leads to the study,
- place the study within the larger context of the scholarly literature, and
- reach out to a specific audience.

(iii) Statement of the problem

This section needs to convince the reader of sponsor to continue reading the proposal. You should capture the reader's attention by stating the problem clearly, its background and consequences and the resulting research. Statement of the problem should be brief and to the

point. Problem statements that are broadly designed cannot be addressed adequately in one study.

(iv) Purpose/Aim of study

A broad statement indicating what the researcher intends to do about the problem being investigated. Why carry out the study? Why now?

(v) Objectives of the study

In this part, purpose of investigation is addressed. It is here that you lay out exactly what is being planned by the proposed research. The objectives flow naturally from the problem statement giving the reader concrete and achievable goals. The objective should be stated clearly and must be testable. The objective should be specific and are important because they determine the kind of research questions to be asked; Data collection and analysis procedures to be used. The research objective section is the basis for judging the remainder of the proposal and ultimately the final report.

vi) Research questions

These refer to the questions which a researcher would like to be answered by undertaking the study. The research questions are more of objectives put in a question form. In case where the objectives are general statements then it may be necessary for the research questions to be included. They should be specific and guiding to the study.

vii) Hypothesis

Hypothesis is a suggested solution to a problem. It remains largely a guess until facts are found to confirm or describe it. Hypothesis is generally generated by the theory being used. This may or may not be included in the proposal, depending on the type and nature of the research. Hypotheses are usually incorporated if statistical testing is to be used.

viii) Significance of the study (justification)

Highlights the reasons for conducting the research like what gaps in knowledge would the study address? Will it contribute to the solution of an immediate problem? Who will the research benefit?

ix) Limitations and delimitations

A limitation is an aspect of the study that the researcher knows it may rely affects the results or the generalizability of the result but has no control over it.

It's a factor that will affect the study but the researcher has no control.

Examples you might not force people to answer personal question and cannot force them or you do not know whether the statement is true. Delimitation on the other hand is an aspect that can be controlled by the researcher. Example you can control the sample size of people you want to access. The sample size, the location of the study and how many people you want to help in the study.

Literature review

There is need for the review of both theoretical and empirical literature. This is of necessary indispensable part of the proposal.

Research Methodology

This section gives a detailed procedure of the methods to be used for the study.

The literature review section is used as the basis of methodology invention.

This section should also provide information on the data one intends to use, sources of the data and characteristics of that data. It will also indicate whether there is any manipulation to be done on the data.

Research design

The design describes what one is going to do in technical terms. This section should include as many subsections as needed to show the phases of the project provide information on your proposed design for tasks such as sample section and size, data collection method, instrumentation, procedures and ethical requirements. When more than one way exists to approach the design, discuss the methods you rejected and why your selected approach is superior.

Data analysis

A brief section on the methods used for analyzing the data is appropriate for research projects. Describe your proposed treatment and theoretical basis to use the selected techniques.

Appendices

Any detail that enforces the body of the proposal can be included in an appendix. These include researcher vitae, budget details, sample data collection instruments (if any), definition of terms etc

Bibliography

For all projects that require literature review, a bibliography is required. Use the reference format required by the sponsor/supervisor.

Time plan and budget

Time plan is important for monitoring the development of the study. One should set out a time plan for literature review, a draft report and final report.

One should also estimate the resources that are going to be committed to the project. There is need to establish the main cost component like travel cost, stationery, researcher and research assistant cost, subsistence. (Accommodation and meals) and equipments (software,computers, microscope) and finally miscellaneous (10% of total budget)